

DARKSTAR ONE

A Near-Perfect Blend

In the drought that followed *Freespace 2*, we'd given up hope of seeing even a half-decent space combat game, and *Darkstar One's* (DS1) emergence from the Shadows can only signal good things for the genre.

The Story

DS1 is about Kayron Jarvis, a young pilot who inherits a mysterious ship from his father—the Darkstar One. The ship has the unique ability to upgrade itself when the time comes, making it even more powerful as time goes by. In this ship, Kayron must now travel the galaxy in search of his father's murderer. He will encounter the whole spectrum of galactic species, notably the vile Thul. Of course, he'll also have to earn money to upgrade the ship, for which he needs to take on assignments ranging from simple escort missions to hunting down pirates. The game's story is a long one, and while it's hardly gripping, it does generate enough curiosity to find out what happens next. You're not really confined to the story—you can take on side missions aplenty, raking in the moolah for each assignment. You can also indulge in trade and smuggling, and the principle behind making money thus is quite simple—buy low, sell high.

The Ship

Where other games would start you off on a ship with an eggshell for a hull, the Darkstar One is a ship that starts out very powerful, and when fully kitted out is nigh-on invincible. You control the ship with the mouse—quite twitchy, one might mention. There's also no option to tweak mouse sensitivity, so either get a joystick or get used to it. However, the initial training missions are well-done, and get you familiar with the ship's other controls in a snap. To upgrade the Darkstar One, you'll

need to find artefacts to absorb. They're all located inside asteroids, and flying into them down the mining tunnels is a heady, disorienting experience, and plenty of fun. There are more than a hundred things you can buy for your ship apart from these “natural” upgrades, so the number of combinations you can come up with boggles the mind.

The Graphics

DS1 has a huge array of ship models, each exquisitely detailed. In addition, it brings to outer space a beauty that hasn't been touched by other games. The settings are sadly repetitive—one planet, one trading station, one or more research stations, and a nearby asteroid field optional. Still, textures and lighting is brilliant, and you can't take your eyes off it. There is a graphics bug in this though—if you turn off anti-aliasing (we did it to speed up the game), the display goes all wonky. Aberrations ranged from shaky screens to everything becoming a set of glowing edges on a black background. You'll need a patch to fix this.

The Verdict

Unlike games like *X3: Reunion*, which focused more on trade and economy and rendered themselves boring, *Darkstar One* knows where its heart is—combat. Even the seemingly harmless assignments often end in skirmishes with pirates, keeping the fun alive. Trade is simple and no-nonsense, and the Time Acceleration feature ensures you don't need to travel long, boring distances. The game is open-ended enough to keep you happy, but following the very complex storyline is entertaining enough for anyone. Voice acting is inconsistent—sometimes good, but sometimes bordering on the level of school plays. We also encountered some issues with the copy-protection—the game would just freeze and send the hard disk into a spinning frenzy every once in a while. Definitely one title you want to check out—make sure you patch it though.

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Rating: **8/10**

Developer: **Ascaron**

Publisher: **CDV**

Minimum System Requirements:

Intel/AMD 1.6 GHz, Windows XP (32-bit),

512 MB RAM, DX9-compatible 128 MB

graphics card